

Foreword

Before we even start with the book and the 20 things they don't tell you about parenting... (there are a lot more than 20 things), but let's start with the basics and talk about the things they DO tell you about having children (and why we all fall for them anyway).

You know who I'm talking about. The cheerful, glowy-eyed parents who gently pat your shoulder when you mention you're thinking of having kids, and with a knowing smile, they say things like:

"It's the most rewarding job in the world", or "Once the baby sleeps through the night, it gets easier", and of course the "You'll miss these days when they're older."

Lies. Beautiful, well-meaning, loving lies. Okay—not all lies. Maybe half-truths. But still, there's a lot they don't tell you (hence this book). Mostly because if people were brutally honest about parenting, humanity might stop reproducing.

So, in the spirit of honesty and sleep-deprived solidarity, here are some of the most common lies you're told about having children.

You'll just know what to do.

Oh? Will I? Because I didn't just know how to swaddle a flailing infant at 3 a.m. I didn't just know which cry meant "hungry" and which one meant "my blanket is twisted slightly, and my life is over." I didn't just know that babies can projectile poop in ways that defy physics.

The truth is: you don't just know. You learn. You fail. You Google. You cry. You call your tribe. You try again. And eventually, yes—you figure some things out. But don't believe for a second that parental intuition is something that magically downloads into your brain at birth.

Sleep when the baby sleeps.

That's just... not a thing.

When the baby sleeps, you: Wash bottles. Fold laundry. Shovel cold food into your mouth. Cry softly while staring at the wall. Sit in stunned silence because it's the first time all day the house isn't vibrating with noise. Never mind trying to maintain a career.

Sleeping when the baby sleeps sounds like a sweet fantasy whispered by a person who has never had a baby.

Kids are cheaper than you think.

Have you seen the cost of diapers, wipes, formula, clothes they outgrow in a week, preschool, toys, medicine, birthday parties, activities, and the random crap you buy online at 2 a.m. because some parents on Instagram swore it “changed their lives”?

Add on therapy (for you), overpriced organic snacks, and the weird obsession they’ll develop with a toy that’s no longer sold in stores—and yeah, kids are not cheap. They’re walking, talking financial black holes that you love more than anything.

It gets easier.

It doesn’t get easier—it gets different.

The newborn stage? Exhausting.
Toddler years? Chaos with legs.
Preschool age? Negotiations and sass.
(We haven’t even thought of our son’s upcoming teenage years!)

Every stage has its joys, yes. But also, its own specific flavour of madness. Don't wait for it to "get easier." Embrace the fact that it's just a constantly evolving circus.

Your life will be back to normal in no time.

What is normal?
Sleep? Spontaneity? Silence?

Nope. Your life shifts completely. Your schedule, your priorities, your brain, your body—everything changes. You won't go back to who you were before, and honestly, you shouldn't want to. You're a whole new version of yourself now. Slightly more frazzled, more caffeinated (or medicated) and much more in love than you ever imagined.

You'll have so much fun playing with them!

Okay, yes—sometimes. The giggles. The cuddles. The silly voices.

But here's what "playing" also includes:

Pretending to be a robot for an hour.

Building endless tracks for his Monster Wheel Trucks

Transferring all the dirt from the garden to his room.

Sitting through a various theatre shows that's hours long and accompanied by someone with the attention span of a French bulldog.

It's love. It's bonding. It's also mind-numbing. And that's okay.

You'll barely remember life before kids.

This one is almost true.

You will remember. Fondly. You'll remember sleeping in. Long showers. Quiet meals. Watching an entire movie in one sitting. Going to the bathroom alone. Not being depressed.

And sometimes, you'll miss that life. And then you'll feel guilty for missing it.

But that's okay. It doesn't mean you love your child any less—it means you were a person before this, and you still are.

Every moment is precious.

Yes, the idea of this is lovely. But have you ever tried to appreciate the “preciousness” of a moment while wiping poop at 3 a.m.?

Not every moment is magical. Some are gross. Some are chaotic. Some will make you want to throw your child and yourself into the nearest laundry basket and hide.

You'll look back one day and appreciate the journey—but that doesn't mean every single moment feels like gold at the time. And that's normal.

You'll be a natural.

You will feel like a fraud often.

You'll Google everything. You'll second-guess your instincts. You'll watch other parents and wonder how they seem to have it all together. (Spoiler alert: They don't.)

You'll mess up. You'll cry. You'll lose your temper. And guess what? You'll still be exactly the parent your child needs.

So, the question is...Why Do They Lie?

Maybe it's not really lying. Maybe it's selective memory. Maybe it's hope. Maybe it's survival. Maybe it's because we feel guilty about complaining about this amazing blessing in our lives. Maybe it's the brain's way of softening the sharp edges of parenting so we don't all walk around in a permanent state of panic.

And maybe, just maybe, it's because the truth is more complicated than a single sentence. Because parenting is brutal and beautiful and maddening and magical—all at the same time.

So, the next time someone says, “You’ll love every second,” you’re allowed to smile, nod politely, and then go scream into a pillow, and that is fine!

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Intro

Thrown Into the Deep End...Skye wasn't in a rush to meet the world, but the world had other plans. Born in July 2019, almost 12 weeks premature, he arrived before he was ready—tiny, fragile, and fighting for every breath. The doctors had to resuscitate him, and from that moment on, our lives were never the same.

He spent months in the hospital, surrounded by beeping machines, watchful nurses, and the steady hum of a neonatal unit that became our second home. Every gram of weight gained was a victory. Every stable breath felt like a miracle. The doctors and nurses adored him—this tiny warrior who refused to back down. And then, finally, after what felt like an eternity, we got the news: he could come home.

After months of fighting to get him home due to adoption regulations and a very slow South African Home Affairs Process, it was time! But as fate would have it, just as we were ready to bring our little boy into the world outside those hospital walls... the world shut down. COVID-19 arrived, and with it, lockdowns, fear, and isolation.

Suddenly, I wasn't just a new parent—I was a new parent in a global crisis. And to make things even more challenging, my husband was deployed back to Iraq for seven months.

There I was. Alone. A baby. A pandemic. And absolutely no idea what I was doing.

The journey into parenthood wasn't just a learning curve—it was a crash course in survival. Sleepless nights, endless worry, and a tiny human who depended on me completely.

The outside world was chaos, but inside our little bubble, I had one job: to keep him safe, to keep him thriving, to figure it all out as I went. Oh yes, and then I also got Covid.

It wasn't pretty. It wasn't perfect. But we made it.

And that was just the beginning...

Chapter 1:

True Love Takes Time

The first time I met Skye, I didn't know what to expect. Sure, I had seen photos, heard stories, and knew in my heart that this little boy was meant to be part of our family, but I had no idea what it would feel like in that very first moment. As soon as we walked into the room, I saw him. He was sitting on the other side, looking a little unsure, a little nervous, just like I was. And in that moment, despite all the anticipation, I didn't feel this overwhelming flood of love. I felt... something else.

I loved him already, of course. I knew I would. But the instant connection I'd imagined—this profound, immediate bonding—just wasn't there. I had pictured myself picking him up and feeling as if we had always been together. But it didn't happen that way. Instead, I felt a little nervous, a little unsure. How could I not? We were meeting for the first time, and the responsibility that came with it was immense. This wasn't just a new addition to the family; this was a life we were taking on, a child who would forever change the way I lived, loved, and saw the world.

It wasn't like the movies where you lock eyes with your child, and everything falls into place. There

was no instant, tear-jerking moment where everything clicked.

But you know what? That's okay.

I think part of me was afraid that I wasn't "feeling" what I was supposed to feel. It was hard not to compare it to the storybook versions of adoption that people often share. But I soon realised that this moment—this meeting, this process—wasn't going to be like everyone else's. This was our journey. And that's when it hit me: The love wasn't supposed to be instant. It wasn't supposed to feel perfect from the very first second.

It was going to grow, and it was going to take time.

We had spent years dreaming about the child we would eventually adopt. My husband Sebastian and I had talked endlessly about the future, about what kind of parents we would be. We knew we were ready, but no amount of preparation could've really prepared us for the reality of what it meant to welcome a child into our lives. Sure, we were prepared for sleepless nights, endless messes, and every possible parenting challenge, but there's something that shifts when you hold your child in your arms for the first time. It's this understanding that life will never, ever be the same again. And for that moment, you just need

to take a deep breath and accept that it's okay not to feel everything in that one second.

When I first held Skye, it wasn't like the movies, but it was perfect in its own way. He was so tiny, so fragile, and yet full of strength. It's strange, isn't it? The way children can be so small but seem to carry the weight of the world on their tiny shoulders. And for a moment, I just held him, unsure of what to say, unsure of how to help him feel at ease. But I whispered to him, "I'm Dada, and you're safe now. You're home." I don't know if he understood my words, but I felt them with every fibre of my being.

It's funny how love works. How it builds over time. There's no magic formula, no instant fix for what it means to be a parent. It's something you must earn, day by day, moment by moment. I remember the first time Skye smiled at me. It wasn't immediate. It took time, trust, and some awkward moments where we both had to find our rhythm. But one day, he just looked at me and smiled, and that smile was everything. It was as if he knew that I was his Dada, and I knew that he was mine. It was a slow burn, but it was everything I needed.

We had moments where it felt like we were speaking different languages. He had his own way of communicating, and I had to figure out how to listen to him. Sometimes, his little hands would

pull at my shirt, and I'd wonder what he needed. Was he hungry? Tired? Or was he just wanting some comfort in a new world? The uncertainty was both thrilling and terrifying.

But slowly, I learned. I learned that love isn't something you rush. It's something you let develop naturally. You can't force it. And no one tells you that before you become a parent. They talk about the joy, the sleepless nights, the mess, and the chaos, but they don't mention that the bond you share with your child will grow in unexpected ways, sometimes slowly, sometimes all at once.

Sebastian and I, as parents, were also learning how to navigate our roles in this new family dynamic. Being a Dada didn't come with a manual, and neither did being a Papa. We were figuring it out as we went, but we knew we had each other to lean on. There was no blueprint for how this was going to unfold. Every day was a new adventure—new challenges, new rewards, new moments of joy.

But the most important thing I've learned over time is that love doesn't always come with fireworks. Sometimes, it's quiet. It's a soft touch, a glance shared, a moment where you just get each other. And I think, in a way, that's even more beautiful than the rush of emotions you see in the movies.

Being a father to Skye has taught me that love is a journey. And while I might not have felt that instant connection when I first met him, every day since then has been filled with moments that have deepened our bond in ways I couldn't have imagined. There's no timeline for love, no rushing it. It's something that grows slowly, carefully, with every shared laugh, every tear wiped away, and every moment that we simply are together.

So no, it wasn't an instant connection. But every day with Skye has brought us closer, and now, looking back, I wouldn't trade a single second of the journey. The connection we have today? It's more than I ever could've imagined, and it's built on a foundation of patience, trust, and the understanding that love doesn't need to be instant—it just needs time to grow.

I am a firm believer that children choose their parents, and Skye is a living example of that. He has taught me more about life and love than I can ever explain, and this is a relationship I will always pour every fibre of my being into, daily, by choice.

Chapter 2:

The Absolute Tiredness of Parenting

Before Skye, I thought I knew what tired was. After all, I had pulled countless all-nighters, travelled across time zones, and survived meetings that should have been emails. I had a pretty solid handle on fatigue. But then, parenthood came in like a wrecking ball.

Parent tired? It's a different beast. A much, much bigger beast that doesn't let you sleep for months at a time. It's a monster that sneaks up on you at 3 AM when you're woken by a tiny voice saying, "Dada, wake up" And even though you've had about two hours of sleep, you get up, shuffle back to his room to make sure he is comfortable. Why? Because, despite the exhaustion, you'll always put your child's needs first. Even when you're pretty sure you can't form a complete sentence without sounding like you're still asleep.

There's a special kind of tiredness that only comes from being a parent. It's the tiredness that makes your brain feel like it's in a fog, and your body feels like it's dragging an anchor with each step. You'll experience that glorious moment when you realise you haven't had a full night of sleep in... well, you can't remember how long. And

somehow, you still function. You might not be fully functional, but you somehow manage to make breakfast, get the kid dressed (with a few battles along the way), and make it through the day. All while running on fumes.

I remember one night when Skye was about two years old, and it felt like the universe was conspiring against us. He had been battling a cold, and his little body couldn't settle down. There I was, rocking him back to sleep for the fifth time that night...all while I was battling Covid. But no matter how tired I was, something in me couldn't rest. There's a certain parental instinct that kicks in when you have a sick child. You can't leave them alone, even if your body feels like it's about to collapse. I remember that night, holding Skye in my arms, my eyelids so heavy that I wasn't sure I could keep them open. Crying, tired, but I stayed up. I stayed up because, in that moment, I knew I had to be there for him. I was his Dada, and that meant I would do whatever it took—even if it meant getting no sleep for the next week.

And the next day, we got up again. Because somehow, we always do.

There's something almost surreal about the tiredness that comes with parenting. It's like your body forgets what "rest" even means. I once found myself napping at 3 PM, curled up on the couch,

when Skye came over to me, tugged on my sleeve, and asked, “Dada, I’m hungry” I opened my eyes, and for a moment, I felt like I had travelled into some other dimension where sleep was a distant memory. “Huh?” I said, blinking like an owl. “Uh... do you want cereal?” Because, at that point, the idea of cooking an actual meal was too much to fathom.

It’s also the kind of tired that doesn’t have an off switch. There’s no real break. Weekends? They’re just like weekdays, except now there are playdates, trips to the park, and more questions about why Hot Wheels monster trucks are the best. The only time you can really rest is when they’re finally asleep... and that’s when you realise, you’re so tired you can barely keep your eyes open to enjoy the rare moment of peace.

I can’t tell you how many times I’ve caught myself thinking, “Just five more minutes of sleep. Please, just five minutes...” But those five minutes turn into fifteen, then thirty, and before you know it, you’ve crossed over into some alternate dimension where time no longer exists.

But in all of this, there’s a strange, inexplicable beauty. Yes, it’s exhausting. Yes, you feel like your body might give out after a week of sleepless nights. But it’s also worth it. Because as tired as you are, you’re also full of love, joy, and pride.

And somehow, that's enough to keep you going. You get through it, not just for yourself, but for them. For Skye. For your family.

And eventually, you start to accept that tiredness is just part of the gig. Sure, you might get a couple of hours of sleep here and there. You might even remember what it's like to be well-rested (although that seems like a distant dream now). But in the end, it's the love and the moments with your child that make it all worth it.

One day, Skye won't wake up and ask for me, nor climb into bed with me for comfort. And I'll look back on these days—exhausted, bleary-eyed, and still running on adrenaline—and I'll miss them.

I'll miss the constant need. I'll miss the way he looked at me like I was his everything. And I'll even miss the early mornings when the only thing I could do was drink coffee and pray that it worked its magic.

But for now, I know that the tiredness is just part of the ride. And as tired as I am, I wouldn't trade a single minute of it.

Chapter 3:

Your house will never be fully clean again

Before I became a dad, I had this vision of what life would be like once I had my own family. My house would be clean—no, spotless. Every surface would shine, every corner dust-free. I would have the kind of house that people would walk into and say, “Wow, this is so tidy!” The kind of home that felt serene, calm, and—let’s be honest—like an Instagram-worthy catalogue of organisation and cleanliness.

Fast forward to now, and I can tell you one thing with complete certainty: your house will never be fully clean again. And honestly, it took me a while to admit, and accept, that...no wait...I’m still trying to accept it.

It’s not just about the crumbs scattered across the kitchen floor or the stray toys that seem to multiply by the hour. It’s the realisation that as a new dad, the concept of a perfect home just doesn’t exist anymore. Not when there’s a baby crawling around, a dog shedding, a partner juggling work and life, and a whole bunch of new chaos that comes with the responsibility of caring for a little human.

And yes, let me be clear here: I'm someone with OCD. I've always prided myself on being a neat freak. Everything in its place, every speck of dust wiped away the moment it appears. But then... everything changed. I became a dad.

The first time I realised my house was no longer going to be pristine was when the baby arrived. You think you've prepped for parenthood, right? You've read the books, you've stocked up on diapers, and you've even got a cleaning routine in place (because, of course, you're OCD). But nothing prepares you for the actual mess that comes with a newborn.

The bottles. The blankets. The diapers. The tiny socks that somehow vanish in the tumble dryer. You think, "Okay, I can handle this." But then, one day, you step on a Hot Wheels car in the middle of the night because you forgot to put it away. Or worse, you walk into the kitchen to find that your partner has left the counter covered in dried baby food while trying to juggle the baby, the laundry, and the dishes. And you find yourself staring at it, wondering if you've failed somehow.

The answer, of course, is no. You haven't failed. You've just stepped into the reality of having a child in the house. And that reality is messy. Very, very messy. It's not the end of the world—it's just

that the standards of cleanliness you once held so high must be let go, bit by bit.

What I've come to realise is this: no matter how hard I try; I will never get my house back to the way it used to be. I'll never get back that obsessive perfection where the bathroom floors are so clean you could eat off them (although, I'm not sure why anyone would want to eat off a bathroom floor in the first place...). The toys will always be out. The laundry will never be done in one sitting. The dust will continue to gather in corners where I just cleaned.

And you know what? That's okay.

I've learned that I can't let my need for order and perfection overwhelm me. Parenthood has taught me that the mess is part of the experience. The toys scattered across the living room aren't just clutter—they're signs of a childhood being lived. The crumbs on the kitchen floor? They're a reminder of the snacks and meals we've shared, the chaos of trying to feed a child who insists on tossing half of their food on the floor. The laundry piled up in the basket. It's the result of trying to keep up with the constant need for fresh baby clothes, burp cloths, and blankets.

Every day brings something new—something messy, something chaotic, something that will inevitably require a clean-up. But it also brings moments of joy: the tiny giggles, the first steps, the first time your baby reaches up to you for comfort. Those things don't care if there's dust on the shelf or a dirty dish in the sink.

As a new dad, I've learned to embrace the imperfection. I've learned to understand that no matter how many times I clean, my house will always return to a state of "lived-in." I'm not saying I've given up on keeping things organised—I still try, but I don't let the mess dictate my happiness. And I certainly don't let it stress me out like I used to.

Parenthood has a way of teaching you that the small things—the messes, the imperfections—are often the most meaningful. The baby's giggle, the way their tiny hands grab onto you for support, the sight of them learning to crawl toward a toy they've never seen before. Those things are way more important than having a spotless home.

At the end of the day, I've realised that it's okay if the house isn't spotless. I'm still the same person, but I'm growing, evolving, and learning to appreciate the little messes. Those messes tell a story. They tell the story of our life together—the messy, chaotic, beautiful life of being a new dad.

So, here's the reality: Your house will never be fully clean again. And that's not a bad thing. Embrace the mess. Because when the mess fades, the memories of this chapter will stay with you forever. And trust me, those are the things that matter most.

Chapter 4:

Silence is Terrifying

You know that moment, right? When you're in the middle of a hundred different tasks—folding laundry, trying to make dinner, and maybe even sneaking a moment to scroll through your phone—and suddenly, it gets quiet. Too quiet. The kind of silence that makes every muscle in your body tense up because, as any parent will tell you, silence when you have kids can only mean one thing: trouble.

I'll be honest—I've learned to fear the quiet. It's a rule that's proven true every single time: When Skye is suddenly silent, you can bet your life that something is either broken, drawn on, or eaten. And it's usually something expensive, permanent, or both.

I remember this one time when I was in the other room, getting ready for work. It had been a relatively peaceful morning, and I was beginning to believe that maybe—just maybe—I could have a moment to myself to look professional and not wear a cap work...again! Then, the silence hit. Skye had been drinking his tea and eating his breakfast in living room, but now? Nothing. I should've known better. I should've known that when the noise stops, the mischief begins.

I tiptoed into the living room, trying not to alert him to my presence, like I was some kind of detective on a mission. And there he was—sitting on his chair, completely still. At first glance, it seemed like everything was fine. But then I looked closer. And that's when I saw it.

The carpet. The tea. The soaked cat.

The centrepiece of our living room. It now looked like it had been a victim of a tea tsunami, and even our poor cat, Saffi, was a victim.

At that moment, I realised something—this wasn't just a mess. This was a masterpiece of chaos. The kind of art that only a toddler could create, where the canvas is anything within arm's reach and the medium of choice is whatever happens to be nearby...in this case, tea. But did I appreciate it in that moment? No.

I'll be honest: there was a second where I wanted to scream. But I didn't. Instead, I took a deep breath and walked over to him, trying my best to hold it together. He looked up at me with those big, innocent eyes and said, "Dada, look, Saffi is clean!" And in that moment, as frustrating as it was, I couldn't help but laugh.

Still, the mess was real.

But that's parenthood, isn't it? The silence that precedes the chaos, the quiet before the storm. And while it's terrifying in the moment, it's also kind of... magical. In a way, it reminds you that your kid is exploring the world around them, discovering boundaries, and testing their creativity—even if it's at the expense of your furniture.

And then, of course, there are the times when the silence is the result of a snack-related disaster. There's an eerie peace that settles over the house when Skye sneaks into the kitchen and decides to help himself. One of his favourite activities is finding food he's not supposed to have, and without fail, it always involves the most inconvenient, hard-to-clean item he can find.

This is when you learn to embrace the mess. Because as terrifying as it is when the silence falls, it's also the sign of a kid who is finding his way in the world, learning that not everything is meant to be touched, explored, or smeared. But those lessons come with consequences, and those consequences are typically a clean-up job that involves more than just a mop and some disinfectant. It often requires a deep breath, a dose of humour, and an acceptance that your house will never truly be "clean."

And then, there's the silent eating. The moments when Skye discovers the joy of sneaking food. It could be something simple, like cookies—or it could be the entire stash of sweets we had hidden in the jar on the shelf. And when I say, “silent eating,” I mean the kind of silence where you don't even hear the crunch of chips or the rustling of a snack bag. No, this is the sneaky silence—the one that makes you wonder, “How long has he been in the kitchen? How much has he eaten?” “Why is the fridge door open?”

The worst part? When you catch them mid-sneak and try to intervene, they look at you like you're the villain. I'll never forget the first time Skye grabbed a cookie when he thought I wasn't looking. He sat there, crumbs covering his face, holding up the half-eaten cookie with a look of pure joy.

It's the denial that gets me every time. No child, no matter how cute, will ever admit they've just devoured an entire snack stash.

But you know what? In the end, you learn to laugh it off. Because silence is a reminder that, for all the messes and the chaos, the little ones are just out there figuring out the world. They're creating, exploring, and doing what they do best—making memories (and making us laugh, even if it's through the frustration).

And so, while silence will always be terrifying in its own way, it's also a gift. Because when it's quiet, it means your child is learning. It means they're testing their boundaries, and maybe, just maybe, they're creating something new, even if it's in the form of a broken vase, a chewed-up shoe, or a kitchen full of flour.

Chapter 5:

The Smell of Pee Is Inevitable

You don't realise how much your life will change when you have a boy until you experience the smell. The distinct smell. The kind that no amount of cleaning supplies, air fresheners, or candles can erase. The kind of smell that haunts you—not just in the bathroom, but in every room of the house, in your clothes, and sometimes, if you're unlucky, in your hair.

Before Skye, I thought I had a handle on basic bathroom hygiene. I mean, I've lived in apartments and shared spaces—I knew how to clean a toilet. But the moment Skye entered the picture, I quickly realised that I was in for a whole new world of challenges. The bathroom, my friends, is not just a place to clean up—it's a battlefield. And I've been on the front lines, fighting the pee war for years now.

Let me tell you: It starts innocently enough. Potty training is something that every parent knows they must go through, but nothing prepares you for the reality of it. One day, you're teaching your son to use the potty like a big boy, and the next, you're scrubbing pee off the walls, the floor, the

toilet seat, and—let's be honest—everywhere. And no, I'm not exaggerating. It's everywhere.

For some reason, boys seem to have this incredible ability to miss the target. I don't know how they do it, but they do. It's like they have a radar for finding the areas outside the bowl to hit. The floor? Check. The walls? Check. The ceiling? Yes, sometimes. It's like a modern-day masterpiece of chaos, and it's all because of pee.

The first time I walked into the bathroom after Skye had used the toilet alone, I thought I had stepped into a warzone. I opened the door, and there it was—the unmistakable smell. It hit me like a ton of bricks. And I'll admit, for a moment, I just stood there, taking it all in. The tiles? Covered in pee. The toilet seat? Soaked. The entire bathroom? A disaster zone of liquid that defied the laws of physics. How had one little boy managed to cover so much surface area with so little? It was baffling. And yet, there it was. I couldn't escape it. It was like the scent of parenthood itself, clinging to every corner.

I couldn't blame Skye, though. After all, he was learning. But man, was it a learning curve for me as well. The first few months were nothing but me following him around with cleaning supplies, disinfectant sprays, and a prayer. I started buying in bulk—those giant packs of disinfecting wipes

that were supposed to be used in an office, not a home. But I wasn't going to risk it. No amount of cleaning could prepare me for the endless "pee accidents" that seemed to happen even after Skye had become potty trained. The smell? It lingered. Always.

But then there's the aftermath. The moment when Skye gets older, and you think, "Ah, he's figured it out now." Oh, no. I wish. Skye, like many boys, has a fascination with aiming. Sure, it sounds good in theory. He stands there, proud of himself, and says, "I got it, Dada!" But then you go in to check, and somehow the toilet is still a crime scene. The bathroom is drenched in urine, but now it's worse—because the smell has started to take on new, more intense layers.

You might ask yourself, "How is it possible for a bathroom to smell this bad after you've cleaned it?" It's like you've crossed into some new dimension where even bleach and air fresheners can't break through. You might even have that moment of doubt, wondering if you somehow did something wrong. Is it your fault? Are you not cleaning enough? The truth is, it doesn't matter how often you scrub the floors, wipe down the walls, or change out the trash bag in the bathroom. It's an inevitable force of nature. Pee is life.

As the months go on, you get better at accepting it. You learn the little tricks—like always having a bottle of air freshener on hand or strategically placing a few scented candles around the house. You start to recognise the smell and, eventually, even become immune to it. You know exactly what it smells like after Skye's been in the bathroom for a few minutes, and by now, it's become so normal that it almost doesn't faze you.

But then, just when you think you've got it under control, something happens that makes you question everything. One afternoon, as I was walking down the hallway, I saw Skye standing in front of the bathroom mirror, looking guilty. And then I noticed it. The smell. It was thick in the air. And my heart sank. I walked in, expecting the usual mess.

But instead, I saw him standing there, wiping down the sink, his hands wet from washing them. And there, on the bathroom floor? Not pee—but toothpaste. He had decided to brush his teeth... in the bathroom sink... while standing on the floor. So, in typical Skye fashion, he had created a new mess. It wasn't pee—but it might as well have been. The scent of toothpaste mixed with the lingering, ever-present smell of pee.

Sometimes, I feel like I'm losing this battle. But I've come to accept it. It's a part of life when you're

raising a boy. You clean the bathroom, you scrub the toilet, and no matter what, the smell of pee is just a reminder that your son is growing, learning, and becoming the little man he's meant to be. And, in a way, it's kind of beautiful. Sure, it's frustrating and slightly nauseating at times—but it's also a reminder of how far we've come. How much Skye has learned.

So, yes. The smell of pee is inevitable. But what I've learned is that it's not the smell that matters—it's the moments, the memories, and the fact that Skye is growing and figuring things out. Even if it means I'll be sniffing bleach for the next few years.

Chapter 6:

Your Food Is Not Yours Anymore

I used to believe in the simple pleasures of enjoying a snack in peace. A quiet moment, maybe a chocolate bar, a rusk, or a bag of chips—just me, my food, and a few minutes of blissful solitude. Ah, those were the days. The days before Skye.

Now, let's talk about food. Or, more accurately, my food. Because let me tell you, once you have kids, the concept of "owning" a snack goes out the window. You're no longer a person with rights to your own food. Oh no. You are a provider. A servant. A snack dispenser. A human vending machine. Skye, my sweet boy, has no sense of boundaries when it comes to my snacks, and trust me, it's a lesson in patience.

It all starts innocently enough. You're making yourself a sandwich—nothing extravagant, just a quick Peanut Butter sandwich or maybe a piece of toast with avocado (because you're fancy like that). You take that first bite, and you're feeling pretty good. You deserve it. You've earned it. You're an adult. And then, just like that, it happens. The words come out of nowhere: "Dada, what's that?"

Your mind races. What's that? That's MY food, Skye. But you can't say that. You're a parent. You're supposed to be selfless and kind and generous. You take a deep breath, smile, and say, "Oh, this? Just a snack. Want some?"

And that's when it begins—the slow realisation that the sandwich you just made is no longer yours. In a moment of weakness, you hand over a bite. And then, Skye's eyes light up. You think, "Okay, just this one bite." But that's the point of no return. The next thing you know, he's grabbing the sandwich with both hands, pulling it closer to him, and saying, "Can I have more?"

And just like that, your snack is gone. Poof. Vanished. It's as if you never had it in the first place. The worst part? He's looking at you, eating your food, and the guilt starts to creep in. "Am I a bad parent if I tell him to stop eating my food?" you wonder. You're not. You're just a parent who is trying to enjoy a meal without being attacked by a tiny, snack-hungry creature.

But it doesn't end there. No, my friends. The next stage in this tragic saga is when Skye starts demanding food. At first, it's subtle. A little tap on the leg. "Can I have some, Dada?" It's cute at first. A little tug on your heartstrings, because you just love seeing him share in the joy of food. But soon,

that tap becomes a full-blown, whiny “I want some now!”

And at that point, you realise that the food you thought was yours has been claimed by Skye’s growing appetite. You hand over whatever’s left with a sense of defeat. Not only have you lost the food battle, but you’ve also lost a small piece of your dignity in the process.

Now, let’s talk about snacks on the go. You’re in the car, heading to the store, or driving to pick up groceries. You’ve got a packet of chips or snacks, thinking you’ll enjoy them on the ride. You open the bag, pop a few in your mouth, and boom—Skye’s hand shoots out like a missile, grabbing a handful. Your snack? Gone. Just like that.

And now, there’s the inevitable: Skye eats your snack, and he’s still hungry. So, you open another snack, just to survive the trip. You think, “Okay, this is my moment. I’m going to eat something. It’ll be fine.” But no. It doesn’t work that way. As soon as that bag crinkles, Skye’s eyes narrow in on it. There is no escaping it.

The real kicker comes when you’ve made something special for yourself—a snack that you’ve been dreaming about all day, maybe a bowl of ice cream or a perfectly toasted sandwich with

your favourite toppings. You take one bite, feeling like you've hit the jackpot. But before you can even fully enjoy it, Skye's hand reaches up to you, eyes wide with innocent hunger. "Can I have?" he asks, almost too sweetly.

And there it is. Your moment of weakness. You want to say no, but you can't. You want to hold on to that tiny piece of happiness. You want to tell him, "I just want this one thing for myself!" But instead, you hand him the bowl. "Just one bite," you say. One bite turns into three. Three turns into five. And before you know it, the entire bowl is gone.

And you know what? You'd do it again. Every time. Because you love him. You want to share. But man, there's something magical about the way kids can completely obliterate your snack without even blinking. They somehow manage to turn your personal moments of indulgence into shared experiences—and in that, there's a certain charm. It's frustrating, sure, but also kind of endearing. You may never get a snack to yourself again, but you also get the joy of seeing them light up when they share in the joy of food.

And let's be real: the idea that your food will always be yours is a myth. It's not even about the food anymore. It's about the bond you create. So, you give away your snacks, your meals, your

chocolate bars—and you do it with a smile. Because in the end, you'll always have the memory of that one moment when Skye turned to you, full of joy, and said, "Thanks, Dada."

Chapter 7:

You Will Cry Over Cartoons

Before Skye, I had no idea that children's cartoons could break your heart. I thought they were just cute, colourful distractions to keep kids entertained while you got some time to yourself. Little did I know, I was about to be dragged into a world where animated characters would make me feel all the feels—feelings that I didn't even know cartoons could trigger in adults.

It all started innocently enough, with a cartoon called Bluey. I'd heard a lot of parents talk about it, and I'll admit, I was sceptical. It's just a kids' show, right? What could be so special about it? I had no idea that Bluey would be the gateway to my emotional breakdowns.

The first time I watched it with Skye, I had no expectations. I thought we'd just watch a few funny episodes about a cute dog family, and that would be that. But no. Bluey hit me in ways I wasn't prepared for. I mean, come on—did you see the episode where Bluey's dad, Bandit, breaks down about missing his childhood? He talks about how life has changed and how being a parent has made him grow in ways he didn't expect. It was like they ripped out my heart, stomped on it, and

then handed it back to me while saying, "This is what being a parent feels like."

And then there's the moment when you realise Bluey isn't just a funny cartoon about a family of dogs—it's a mirror for your own life. Every episode is a little nugget of wisdom about parenting, about love, about sacrifice, and about finding joy in the everyday chaos. Suddenly, you're crying over a cartoon dog just learning to share. You're questioning your own parenting skills, wondering if you're doing enough, if your child is as happy as Bluey is when she plays with her family. And all of this, just from a cartoon.

But Bluey is just the beginning. Let's talk about Coco. When Skye and I sat down to watch Coco, I thought it would be a fun, colourful movie about a boy who wants to play music. It was everything I expected—until it wasn't. There's that moment in the movie when Miguel sings "Remember Me" to his great-grandmother, who has forgotten him, and I lost it. I mean, really lost it.

If you've ever had a moment when you realised you might be missing out on something bigger than yourself—your legacy, your family's memories, or your connection with your ancestors—you'll understand why I was sitting on the couch, trying to hold it together, as my face contorted with tears. The thought of not being

remembered by my child? The thought of Skye forgetting me someday? Well, it broke me.

Remember Me isn't just a song; it's an emotional gut punch that hits every parent right where it hurts. It made me realise how fleeting time is, how our kids grow so quickly, and how every moment counts. All of this, from a family-friendly movie about the Day of the Dead.

And then, let's talk about Encanto. I thought I could handle it. I thought I had my emotions in check. But I had underestimated how Encanto would rip through every part of me. The entire movie is about family dynamics, and when you're a parent, family dynamics are everything. You see yourself in every character. You see your child in Mirabel, struggling to find their place. You see your partner in the Abuela, desperately trying to hold everything together, even when it's falling apart.

And then there's the song Surface Pressure. Who doesn't cry when Louisa sings about the weight of the world on her shoulders? Suddenly, you're questioning how much weight you're carrying as a parent and whether you, too, are putting too much pressure on yourself. Are you doing too much, trying to be everything to everyone? The answer is probably yes, and that's when you reach for the tissue box.

But what Encanto teaches you is that it's okay not to have it all together. It's okay to be imperfect. It's okay to cry. And yes, it's okay to let your child see you cry. It's okay for them to see that parenting is hard, that love is complicated, and that family—no matter how quirky—is the glue that holds everything together.

By the time the credits roll, you're a wreck. Your kid's sitting there, looking at you like, "Are you okay, Dada?" And you're just trying to breathe through the tears while pretending it's just allergies.

But here's the thing—these cartoons, these movies, they make us feel. And as a parent, that's something I never expected. I didn't know I'd find myself crying over animated characters. But I did. And I think that's part of what makes parenting so special. It's not just about the funny moments or the chaos. It's about feeling deeply, loving with your whole heart, and having those emotional connections with the little ones you're raising.

You don't get to experience those feelings without being a parent. You don't get to see how beautiful it is to care for someone so much that it physically hurts. You don't get to watch a cartoon and realise that, yes, you are doing your best, and that's enough.

And Skye? He doesn't know it yet, but these moments we share, these films, these songs, these lessons—we're building memories that will stay with him forever. And one day, when he's older, maybe he'll sit down to watch Bluey or Coco or Encanto with his own kids, and he'll understand exactly why his Dada cried over a cartoon.

Until then, I'll be here, crying over cartoons and hugging my kid a little tighter, because I know, deep down, that these moments are fleeting. And they are everything.

Lastly...let me NOT start on The Lion King...total devastation.

Chapter 8:

No One Cares About Your Sleep Needs

(Kids wake up early, especially on weekends, public holidays and school holidays.)

Once upon a time, in a life that now feels like a fever dream, I used to sleep in. I used to wake up when my body decided it was time. I used to roll over in bed, stretch like a satisfied cat, and decide—maybe—to get up, or maybe to stay wrapped in my blanket cocoon for just a little longer.

Then, I became a parent.

From the very moment Skye entered my life, sleep became a luxury, an unattainable dream—an urban legend, even. People say it exists, but no one with a child has seen it. And the most brutal part? Kids don't care. At all.

It doesn't matter if you went to bed at 2 AM because you were finally catching up on some adult TV or watching the Eurovision competition live (a rare event when Bluey, Hot Wheels and Cocomelon don't dominate the screen). It doesn't matter if you were up all night because your child decided that 3 AM was a great time to discuss

deep life questions like “Dada, are you awake?” or “Where is my Monster Truck?”

Your kid? They don’t care.

They will wake up at 6 AM, fresh as a daisy, fully charged like a phone that’s been plugged in all night, ready to go—go where, I don’t know, but they are READY. And they will wake you up too.

And here’s the thing—children don’t gently wake you up. They don’t whisper like a considerate little angel. No. They announce their presence like a SWAT team busting down your bedroom door.

You’ll be jolted awake by a tiny face two inches from yours, staring at you like a horror movie jump scare.

Sometimes, they just poke you repeatedly until you surrender and open your eyes.

Other times, you wake up to tiny hands prying your eyelids apart like some sort of sleep-deprivation experiment.

If they’re feeling extra chaotic, they will sit on you, bounce on the bed, or—my personal favourite—

drag the loudest toy they own directly into your room.

And for what? What urgent crisis could possibly require this level of aggressive morning energy?

“I’m hungry.”

“Can I watch TV?”

“The sun is awake!”

“Is today tomorrow?”

Before kids, weekends meant sleeping in, having lazy mornings, and maybe enjoying a peaceful cup of coffee while scrolling through your phone. Post-kid? Forget it.

Weekends mean absolutely nothing to children. Nothing. Their internal alarms are set at an ungodly hour, and no amount of explaining “it’s the weekend” will convince them to stay in bed.

In fact, they seem to wake up earlier on weekends, just to make sure you don’t get any funny ideas about catching up on sleep. Monday to Friday, you must drag them out of bed for school. But Saturday? Early party in the living room!

The worst part? People warn you about this. Other parents will say, “Enjoy your sleep while you can!” and you’ll nod, thinking, Yeah, yeah, I get it.

You don't.

Not until you're living the reality of being yanked from your dreams at dawn by a tiny dictator demanding breakfast, entertainment, and answers to existential questions all before sunrise.

You'd think that, given how early they wake up, kids would at least appreciate nap time.

No.

Nap time is a war. It's a hostage negotiation. It's you, the sleep-deprived adult, desperately trying to convince a child—who is CLEARLY exhausted—to lie down for just one hour, so maybe, just maybe, you can shut your own eyes for a few minutes.

But they? They fight it like their life depends on it. They act like sleep is some form of medieval torture and they must resist at all costs.

But when they do fall asleep? Oh, the irony. Because now—NOW—you're afraid to move. You tiptoe around like a burglar in your own home, terrified to make a sound, because if they wake up, that's it. Game over. Never mind driving from a kid's party, pulling out all stops to keep your kid awake, because maybe, just maybe, you both can

take a nap at home. Yes, I'm that parent in traffic, singing loudly, making jokes and opening the windows to keep my kid awake...1/10 times it is successful.

And then—when it's finally your turn to sleep at night? That's when they need water, another bedtime story, a different car, a philosophical discussion about death, and, of course, one more kiss and hug.

At some point, you stop fighting it. You stop dreaming about a full 8 hours and start celebrating the small wins.

Four hours of uninterrupted sleep? Victory.

Managing to drink coffee while it's still hot? A miracle.

And eventually, you find yourself adjusting to the insanity. You start waking up before your child on weekends, not because you want to, but because your body has been trained to. You learn to appreciate the quiet moments before the chaos begins.

But most of all, you realise something ridiculous.

Despite the exhaustion, despite the dark under-eye circles, despite the extra grey hair, despite the moments when you think, I might not survive this level of sleep deprivation—you wouldn't trade it for anything.

Well.

Maybe just one uninterrupted nap.

PS: No one told me kids outgrow naps??

Chapter 9:

You Will Hear the Same Question 100 Times

Before becoming a parent, you could ask a question and get a sensible, normal answer. You could even repeat a question, and it wasn't a big deal. But then—THEN—you become a parent, and you will be subject to an entirely new form of interrogation. Your child will ask you the same question so many times, it will make you question your sanity and the entire concept of patience.

It starts innocently enough. Maybe Skye wants to know why the sky is blue. Simple enough, right? So, you answer, giving him the best explanation you can muster. And he looks at you, nods, and then—asks again— “Why is the sky blue?”

You explain it again, but this time, you throw in a little more detail, hoping that will do the trick. But no—he's not satisfied. “But why?” he asks once more, as though he's trying to crack the code to the universe itself. And so, it continues. You, answering why the sky is blue in every possible way you can think of, and him, asking the same question until your brain melts and you begin to wonder if you've been speaking English at all.

And it's not just one question. Oh no. That would be too easy. This becomes a daily ritual of answering the same questions repeatedly, no matter how many times you explain it. You will hear:

- “Why do we have to sleep?”
- “Why can't I eat sweets for breakfast?”
- “Why do I have to go to school?”
- “What are you doing?” (This one is usually asked 3 seconds after you've locked yourself in the bathroom.)

The worst part? No matter how many times you answer, you can never truly predict when the next round of questions will come. It might happen in the middle of breakfast. Or during your Zoom meeting. Or—my personal favourite—while you're on the toilet which is when you're least prepared for deep philosophical discussions.

And the kicker? These questions never really stop. They evolve, sure—sometimes the question turns into “Why do I have to do my homework?” But eventually, they return to the simple ones, like “Why is the sky blue?” except now they've added a new twist: “But how did the sky get that way?”

By the time you've answered for the 100th time, you'll wonder if you've been saying the same thing for hours. Maybe days. It's hard to tell.

Your brain starts to break down. But here's the truth: You'll answer. You'll answer because that's what parents do. You'll try to be patient, even as your inner self is screaming, For the love of all things holy, it's blue because of light scattering! But you'll say it with a smile—because you love them, and because you know that someday, you'll miss hearing “Why?”

Even though right now, you'd pay good money to have five minutes of silence.

Chapter 10:

You'll Become a Master Negotiator, and liar!

Parenthood is a crash course in negotiation. The moment you become a parent; you enter a world where the art of persuasion takes on a whole new level of importance. And let's be clear: it's not just about asking for something. Oh no. It's about the subtle and sneaky ways you get what you want—while simultaneously convincing your child they're the ones getting the better deal. It's a delicate dance. A fine art. It's diplomacy at its finest... but with a whole lot of lying involved.

Let's start with something simple: the vegetable negotiation. It's dinner time. You've made a delicious, healthy meal. The problem? Your child has decided that the vegetables on their plate are, in fact, lava. You try to reason, try to offer an explanation. "But my love, they're good for you! They'll help you grow strong!"

They stare at you, wide-eyed. "I'm already strong!"

And that's when you realise—you've lost. So, you negotiate. You offer a trade:

"How about just one bite? If you take one bite, you can watch TV."

They raise an eyebrow. They know this game. They've played it before. They sit there, unmoved, refusing to budge. You ramp it up. "How about two bites? And then you get 10 more minutes to watch TV."

The stakes are higher now. But here's the twist: You're not negotiating with them. No, you're negotiating with yourself. How much of your integrity are you willing to sacrifice to avoid a tantrum? How many lies can you tell to ensure they eat something and stop making that "I will never eat this" face?

And then, out of sheer desperation, you pull the ultimate card:

"You know, the vegetables will make you as strong as Spiderman."

Boom. You've done it. They take a bite. The trade is made. You've outsmarted them—sort of.

But this negotiation business doesn't end with dinner. Oh no. It bleeds into every aspect of your day-to-day life. Getting them to put on their shoes? "If you put on your shoes, we can leave right now, and you can go play!" (They're going to play anyway, but you've made it sound like leaving the house is the prize.)

And don't forget the bedtime negotiations. This is a classic. It starts with "I'm not tired," followed by "I need water," then "Can I have one more story?" Then comes the real master stroke: "Five more minutes, please?" Of course, this is not a request—it's a well-crafted, unspoken agreement. You both know five more minutes means "at least thirty," but you'll both pretend otherwise.

Then, you become a liar. You lie for peace. You lie because it's easier than explaining the actual truth. "Of course, there's no more sweets..." even though you hid the stash behind the cereal. You'll tell them, "The shop is closed," when it's open for another hour, simply because you need five minutes of quiet. You'll say things like, "I'll get it for you in a minute," when you have absolutely no intention of doing so.

And here's the kicker—they know you're lying. They've got a sixth sense for when you're fudging the truth. "But you said five minutes!" they'll shout as you scramble for an excuse. And you, the seasoned parent, will stand tall and say, "Five minutes, when I'm ready."

Parenthood will turn you into an expert negotiator and a master of bending the truth in ways you never thought possible. You'll navigate the tricky waters of bedtime deals, snack trades, and post-

playtime promises with such finesse that even the world's top diplomats would be jealous.

But here's the secret you'll learn: You do it for them. You negotiate, and yes, you lie sometimes—but only because you're doing whatever it takes to keep the peace, to make them happy, and to save your sanity. Because, at the end of the day, you'll probably be able to get them to bed—and to eat those vegetables—just long enough for you to eat the last piece of cake in peace.

Chapter 11:

Kids have selective hearing

Selective hearing. You've probably heard that term used before, but it takes on a whole new meaning when you're a parent. It's not just about ignoring annoying sounds; no, no. Kids have mastered the art of hearing only the things they want to hear and nothing else.

It starts small. You ask your child to "pick up your toys" or "please clean your room". They stare at you blankly, nodding as if they heard you, but you can see it in their eyes—they didn't really hear you. Oh, they'll hear the ice cream truck coming from a mile away, but your simple, reasonable request? Nothing. It's as if their ears shut off the moment they detect any form of responsibility in their environment.

But wait, it gets better. You could be across the house, whispering to your partner, and somehow your kid will hear exactly what you said. "Are we having pizza for dinner tonight?" they'll yell from the other room, as if they were equipped with a superhuman hearing radar. You'll find yourself scrambling, how did they hear that?

But when it's time for them to do something remotely responsible, your child's hearing goes completely mute. You could shout their name, repeat the request five times, and they'll just keep playing with that toy. You're practically waving your arms in front of their face, and yet—nothing.

And let's not forget the classic "I didn't hear you" routine. You've asked them to do something for the millionth time. You've given them the "look," you've calmly (ha) stated that it's time to stop watching their show and get ready for bed—and what do you hear?

"What??"

No, no—I said the opposite of what you think you heard. I said: "Get off the couch and put your shoes on because we're going to the shop right now!"

They'll repeat the same question back to you: "Can I go to the shop?!" as if the concept of leaving the house is a new, wild idea they've never encountered before. It's like that hearing switch was flipped back on just at the right moment. It's as if they have an innate ability to selectively listen to the one thing they want to hear, and somehow filter out the things that are inconvenient, like "time for bed" or "put the phone down, please."

And then there's the game of "what do you mean you didn't hear me?" You've said "no" ten times. You've repeated yourself like a broken record. Yet they will persist, asking, "But why not? Why can't I have pancakes right before dinner?" Even though they know perfectly well you said "no" earlier. So, you're left in a perpetual loop of repeating yourself, like a parent-version of Groundhog Day.

The real kicker, of course, is when they do hear you—at the most random and bizarre moments. You could be whispering to your partner in another room, saying, "I wonder if I left my keys in the car again," and suddenly you hear:

"Dadda, why are your keys in the car?"

You stop dead in your tracks and think, how in the world...? But they heard it, loud and clear. The important stuff? You're invisible. The completely random, inconsequential things? It's like they've got a superpower, tuned in only to your faintest words about something entirely unrelated to their life.

So, you begin to accept it. You'll speak louder, more dramatically, and probably exaggerate just to make sure they hear you. But honestly, you can't even be mad. Because the truth is, somewhere during their selective hearing, there's

this beautiful, wonderful thing: They're listening to you. They just choose the wrong moments to tune in—and you'll be over here wondering if maybe they do know exactly what they're doing.

Their ears function like high-tech filtering systems: they can block out any command, request, or instruction they don't like while maintaining laser focus on the tiniest sound that benefits them.

I decided to test his hearing one day. I called his name at a normal volume. No response. I repeated it, louder. Still nothing. Then I mumbled something about “monster trucks” under my breath—BOOM, he was right next to me.

So naturally, I conducted a full-blown experiment:

Whispered “clean your room” from five feet away. Nothing.

Whispered “want a new monster truck?” from across the house. Immediate response.

Science confirms selective hearing is real, and it is terrifyingly efficient.

Then there's the worst offender: the delayed selective hearing.

Me: "Skye, put your shoes on."

Skye: No response.

Me: "Skye, come on, let's go."

Skye: Still nothing.

Me: "HEY, PUT YOUR SHOES ON."

Skye: blinks at me "Ohhh... me?"

NO, MY LOVE, I WAS TALKING TO THE PLANTS?!

But then, of course, when I say something that isn't directed at him, he hears everything.

Me (talking to Sebastian): "Maybe we should go get pastries later."

Skye (from two rooms away): "? CAN WE GO NOW? LET'S GO!"

Through much trial and error, I've discovered a few hacks to beat the selective hearing phenomenon:

The Whisper Trick - If I whisper something seriously, like, "Skye, come here, I have to tell you a secret", suddenly he's listening at full capacity. Then I slip in, "And also, go brush your teeth." He's already engaged, so bam—mission accomplished.

The Game Approach – Instead of saying, “Clean your room,” I say, “Let’s see who can pick up the most toys in one minute!” and suddenly, he’s interested. Parenting is just a series of psychological mind games.

The Reverse Psychology Move – This one is powerful. Instead of telling him to do something, I say, “I bet you can’t get into your bed in under 10 seconds.” Now, instead of ignoring me, he’s racing to prove me wrong.

The “I’ll just do it myself and keep your pocket money” Bluff – he’s there in seconds. (This one works for chores too— “I guess I’ll just pick up your toys myself” has surprisingly fast results.)

At the end of the day, kids hear exactly what they want to hear. It’s a mix of pure survival instinct, masterful negotiation skills, and an almost magical ability to detect only what benefits them.

One day, I’ll miss these little selective-hearing battles. I’ll miss the *‘‘Huh?’’ *s and the ‘‘I didn’t hear you’’ excuses.

Chapter 12:

Your Phone/Tablet/TV Is Their Property

When you become a parent, you realise that the concept of personal property goes right out the window. And nothing highlights this more than the moment your child discovers your phone, tablet, or your TV.

It starts innocently enough. You've been using your phone for what feels like five minutes (in reality, it's been two hours). You hear that tiny voice behind you:

"Dadda, your phone?"

You think, "Sure, I'll just check a few things while they occupy themselves with whatever ridiculous app they'll probably destroy." So, you hand it over. Big mistake.

Within moments, your phone is no longer yours. It's a portal into a world of toddler games, endless YouTube Kids videos of people playing TV games and blurry selfies that somehow involve half of their face and the ceiling. In fact, you don't even need to ask for your phone back anymore—because the next time you look at it, you'll notice it's completely dead from playing the most

mindless, battery-draining game ever invented for three hours straight.

And let's not forget the apps you didn't even know existed. You'll be scrolling through your phone one day, and then you'll stumble upon a mysterious app you didn't download. And then you'll see a screenshot they took of the weirdest thing—probably a picture of the dog's paw in a weird position—and you'll realise: Your phone has now become their personal entertainment centre.

Of course, this extends to your TV too. You've spent your whole life binge-watching your favourite shows or enjoying a peaceful hour of Netflix with your partner, when—suddenly—the remote control is in the hands of your little one. And you know the moment you hand that remote over, it's game over.

They'll pick their favourite show, which will not be the show you've been watching, and you're powerless to stop it. Oh, you'll try—you'll try to negotiate, "When your turn is finished, then it's my turn?" But they know exactly how to push your buttons. They know exactly how to manoeuvre the remote just enough to get their show on the screen. Now it's time for them to tune out, completely forgetting that you exist.

But don't kid yourself—this isn't just about your phone and TV. It's about every single device in your home. Your laptop? That's theirs too. They're perfectly happy to open your laptop and start typing random strings of characters as if they're composing the next great work of literature—or more likely a highly classified message only understood by them. Your tablet? They'll find a way to lock you out of it in a nanosecond.

And don't even get me started on your headphones. You used to have a personal sanctuary where you could escape into your music or podcasts. But no—your child sees those headphones, and suddenly, they're the most magical thing in the world. "Can I borrow your headphones?" they'll ask sweetly, as if they're just borrowing your jacket. Sure, go ahead. You'll be lucky if you get them back without a broken wire, and even luckier if they haven't used them to blast the most obnoxious cartoon sound effects for hours.

But perhaps the most eye-opening moment came when Skye asked me one day, "Dada, is the table ours?" I replied without thinking, "Yes, what is ours is yours." He paused for a moment, then asked about the couch, the plants, the books, and everything else in sight. And then, the inevitable happened. He asked about the TV.

It was at that moment I realised—I was trapped. The rules I had just established had come back to bite me. I reluctantly nodded, “What is ours is yours.”

Skye grinned and said, “Great, it’s my turn to watch.”

And just like that, the TV was no longer mine. It was his.

Parenthood has a funny way of turning everything you once considered “yours” into a shared resource, whether you like it or not. The phone? His. The TV? His. The couch? The plants? The entire house? Yep, you guessed it—all his. So, the next time you think about enjoying a little peace and quiet, remember that it’s probably time to hand over the remote. Because, in their world, what is yours is theirs.

There was a time—long ago—when I had control over the TV in my own house. When I could choose a movie, watch a show uninterrupted, and scroll through my phone without a tiny human demanding my full attention.

That time is gone.

But you know what?

One day, years from now, he'll grow up. He won't steal my phone anymore. He won't reprogram my YouTube. And, eventually, I'll have my TV back.

And weirdly... I might miss these chaotic little takeovers.

But for now, if anyone needs me, I'll be watching Hot Wheels Monster Trucks... again!

Chapter 13:

Everything Becomes a Weapon

When you become a parent, you quickly learn that “toys” are not the only things in your home that can be wielded with deadly precision. No, no. The true weaponry of the household lies in the seemingly innocent, everyday objects that can, at a moment’s notice, turn into lethal projectiles.

It starts with spoons. You might think they’re for eating, right? Wrong. In the hands of a toddler, a spoon becomes a boomerang, a catapult, and an airborne missile all in one. I’ve watched, wide-eyed, as a spoon soared across the room in slow motion, headed straight for the dog’s face. The dog, of course, didn’t flinch—it was the spoon that took the brunt of the collision. Who knew that a simple spoon could have such accuracy?

But it doesn’t end there. No, no. That tiny LEGO? Weaponised. That half-eaten sandwich? Projectile. Your child is essentially a ninja in disguise, using the most innocuous objects as tools of destruction. The number of times I’ve been pelted with a stray pillow, or worse—my own shoe—is immeasurable. And let’s not even talk about the shoe. Oh yes, the shoe. It can fly with such speed; it can be mistaken for a dart. And if it lands near

you? Watch out. It will either make you laugh or seriously question your parenting choices.

But here's the twist: It's not just about objects. Suddenly, words become weapons, too. The "Why?" battle, for example, becomes a verbal sword fight you never agreed to participate in. Your child asks why the sky is blue. You give a simple answer. They ask why again. Then again. And again, until you've spiralled into a philosophical debate about the meaning of life, and you are the one questioning why you ever started this conversation in the first place. The repeated "why" becomes a relentless attack that leaves you wondering how much longer you can dodge the barrage.

And then, there's the ultimate weapon: the tantrum. Oh yes. Nothing is more strategically powerful than the unexpected meltdown, which turns even the most peaceful home into a battlefield. One minute, everything is fine, and the next—BOOM.

Your child has gone rogue and is now waging war on their favourite toy, the floor, and let's face it—you. As you try to calm them down, you realise you're out of ammunition. Negotiation? No. Reasoning? Pointless. The tantrum has escalated into full-blown battle mode. At this point, all you can do is brace yourself for the onslaught.

Then there's the cup of tea. Seems harmless enough, right? But to a toddler, that cup is a weapon of mass distraction. Watch in horror as they take that cup, spill it everywhere, and then—whoosh—suddenly they're splashing it around like it's some kind of artistic masterpiece. Meanwhile, you're left cleaning up a milky battlefield with soggy towels and a broken spirit.

And don't forget the toy cars. They're small. They're plastic. But in the hands of a child, they become tiny little missiles, crashing into furniture, the dogs, the cat, your legs, and your face when you least expect it. It's the stealth attack you didn't see coming. One second, you're watching TV, the next—you've got a toy car hurtling toward your eye. What once was a simple toy is now a high-speed projectile aimed at your most sensitive parts.

So, here's the thing: In the chaos of parenting, you realise that everything in your home has the potential to become a weapon. Your kids have turned your once peaceful abode into a war zone, where every spoon is a potential projectile and every sock an artillery shell. But the most terrifying part? You're always on the defensive. You never know when the next attack will come or what innocent item will become a new tool of mass destruction.

But let's be honest—sometimes you just must laugh. Because, as ridiculous as it may seem, there's a weird beauty in watching a tiny human wreak havoc with their makeshift weapons. It's chaotic, it's exhausting, and it's utterly hilarious. And no matter how many times your life is interrupted by flying objects, you wouldn't trade it for anything.

Chapter 14: The Favourite Parent – And the Guilt That Comes With It

(Warning: Feelings ahead.)

No one warns you about this part. You go into parenting thinking it's going to be a united front. A team effort. You and your partner, side by side, wiping noses, attending school events, tag-teaming bedtime stories, and being loved equally and endlessly by your child.

And then—one day—it happens.

Your child, your sweet little bundle of joy whom you've fed, rocked to sleep, protected, sacrificed for, and loved with every cell in your exhausted body... looks you dead in the eyes and says:

“I want Papa.”

And just like that, you are not the chosen one.

It doesn't always happen suddenly. Sometimes it's a slow creep. First, they ask the other parent for their juice. Then only that parent can brush their teeth or wipe their bums (not too sad about this

one). Then it's only them who can put the blanket on just right. And then... bedtime rolls around.

You: "Okay, my love time for bed."

Skye: "NO. I want Papa to do it."

You (still smiling on the outside, crying on the inside): "Okay... sure..."

And there you are, standing awkwardly in the hallway, holding the toothbrush of rejection, wondering if this is how it ends.

You know it's no personal. You know they love you. You've read all the articles. You've seen the quotes on Pinterest.

"Kids switch preferences based on who they need at the moment."

"It's developmentally normal.", "It's a sign of a secure attachment."

Blah blah blah.

But in the moment? It stings. It stings hard.

Because you didn't wake up at 3 a.m. for six weeks straight just to be cast aside like last season's toy. You didn't spend your weekend organising snacks

into tiny shaped boxes just to be told they want the other one.

And sure, you tell yourself to be mature. You nod and smile and say, "Of course, Skye." But deep down? You're halfway to sulking on the kitchen floor with a tub of ice cream.

What makes it worse is that it brings out emotions you didn't expect—jealousy, insecurity, even a bit of resentment. And then? Comes the guilt.

You feel guilty for feeling hurt. Guilty for not being the "secure, evolved" parent who can laugh it off. Guilty for wondering what you did wrong. Guilty for wanting just a little bit of appreciation.

Sometimes, you even start to keep score—mentally, of course. You're not proud of it. But still...

You stayed up all night with a feverish child.

You were the one who wiped the poop explosion off everything.

You figured out the exact temperature that milk needs to be microwaved.

And yet? “I want Papa.”

Sigh.

Here's the truth no one really talks about: kids choosing a favourite parent is normal, temporary, and deeply human.

Sometimes they gravitate to the parent who's softer. Sometimes the one who's firmer. Sometimes the one they saw most that day, or the one who's less strict about snack rules. Sometimes it's completely random. And sometimes, yes, it has nothing to do with you at all.

And you know what else? It flips. Sometimes slowly, sometimes overnight. One minute you're watching from the sidelines, the next you're suddenly the only one allowed to buckle the car seat, cut the sandwich, or sing the teeth brushing song.

It's a reminder that this isn't about being the “better” parent—it's about being available. About being safe. About being the person they can push away and still know you'll be right there when they come running back. Why?...

Because they do come back. They always do....and then the tables turn, and you must now deal with your partner's insecurities about this topic 😊

Chapter 15:

You'll Say Things You Never Expected

Before becoming a parent, there were words you thought you'd never utter. "Stop licking the floor," for example. Why would you ever say that? Surely that's something out of a weird sitcom. And yet, here you are, hands on your hips, looking down at your child who has, for reasons only known to them, decided that the floor is the perfect place to express their newfound love for licking. It's an odd moment in parenting—when your once-clear boundaries between what is normal and what is just weird suddenly blur.

But then there are the other things you'll say, the things you didn't think were even remotely possible to utter without bursting out laughing or questioning your sanity. Things like:

"We don't put that in our ears."

You'd think that's a lesson you could just skip, right? I mean, peas don't belong in ears, just like socks don't belong in the trash bin. Yet, here we are—sitting at the dinner table, attempting to have a grown-up conversation, when you look over to see your child experimenting with the auditory benefits of his food. You can't just leave them to

their discovery. You have to say it, even though it feels like you've entered some strange parallel universe where the rules of decency don't apply.

And then there's the inevitable "Stop licking the dog."

It's a rite of passage in any household with young children, right? How do they even get the idea? At that moment, you realise your ability to speak the unspoken has reached new heights. You didn't know this was a skill you'd need, but now, there you are, baffled by a child who finds it fun to express themselves with their tongue all over your dog.

The oddest part? You're not even shocked. In fact, there's a weird sense of pride when your brain just goes into autopilot mode, as you say, "We don't lick dogs," without even blinking. You've reached a whole new level of parenting. The reply? "But they lick us Dadda!" (Insert awkward silence)

Then comes the infamous "We don't eat sand" moment.

You know the one. You're at the beach, the wind is blowing, the ocean is calling, and you turn around for two seconds to admire the scenery. You then turn back just in time to see your child—

mouth open wide—licking sand. Not sand on the ground, not a clump of dirt, not even a piece of food they're pretending is from a magic land. Nope. They are actively eating sand. So, naturally, you react with, "We don't eat sand," like it's something you've rehearsed and it's totally normal. If you had any doubt about your child's behaviour, you'd suddenly realise it's you who has evolved. You've adjusted. You've become someone who has actively accepted the weirdness of parenting.

And then there's the classic, "We don't put that in our mouth."

This one becomes a daily mantra. Every object, no matter how bizarre, becomes a potential snack. A leaf? A toy car? The dog's squeaky bone? If it can be chewed, they will find a way to put it in their mouth. And no matter how many times you say, "We don't put that in our mouth," you're bound to find a new object in their hands, pressed to their lips like it's a delicacy in some strange food-averse kingdom.

But perhaps the most soul-crushing of them all: "Why did you put your shoes in the toilet?"

This is one of those moments when, as a parent, you can only stand there and stare at the situation

in utter disbelief. There's no explanation. There's no reason. You just look at your child, who is innocently holding up their shoe, now soaked and full of toilet water, like they're trying to hand you a gift you didn't ask for. And all you can do is wonder—how did we get here? And why on earth did they think this was an appropriate decision?

Parenting is full of these unexpected dialogue gems. The things you never thought you'd say in a million years become routine. And while they may make you question the world you live in; they also make you laugh—and sometimes cry a little—because, let's face it, there's nothing more humbling than finding yourself saying, “Please don't lick the dog's tail” at 7 a.m. on a Tuesday. But it's all part of the joy of parenthood. No matter how strange, how absurd, or how utterly random the conversation might get, it's yours to navigate with love, humour, and a whole lot of patience.

Chapter 16:

Going Anywhere Takes Forever

Ah, the illusion of “spontaneity” when you’re a parent. Before kids, leaving the house was as easy as grabbing your keys, heading out the door, and thinking, “What should I do today? Let’s just go!” Fast forward to parenthood, and the mere act of leaving the house becomes an expedition. It’s like preparing for a mini-vacation, except you’re not going anywhere fun, and you’ll probably need a nap afterward.

When you first become a parent, well-meaning people will tell you, “Cherish these moments, it goes by so quickly.” They say this with the kind of wisdom that only a parent who has lived through it can muster. “Enjoy these years,” they advise, as if you’ll blink and suddenly, your child will be packing for college. And you nod, thinking, Sure, that’s true, but not right now—until you’re standing outside your front door with one shoe on, the diaper bag on your back, and a child who won’t get in the car.

Because that’s when the chaos starts. You must gather everything: snacks, drinks, diapers, changes of clothes, that favourite toy they won’t leave without, and, oh yes, their emotional

support blankie. You're ready, but somehow, you've forgotten that your toddler's favourite activity is to test your patience as you try to get them to sit down in the car seat. "No, I'm not going! I don't like the car!" Cue meltdown.

And the more you try to hurry, the more they drag their feet. You tell them it's time to go, and they give you a look like you've just announced you're moving to a new planet. You try to speed it up, and suddenly, their little legs are molasses. You ask, "Are you coming?" and they answer with the most unexpected of responses, "I want to say goodbye to the tree." The TREE. The tree you've passed a million times. You try to reason, but no—this is the most important task in the world right now.

You buckle them in, finally. But wait—did they bring their toy? You forgot their toy! It's like living in a tiny, adorable world of constant negotiation. You forgot to grab the toy? That's an emergency, apparently. And that's when you'll realise—getting out of the car is sometimes just as difficult as getting in the car. You'll stop halfway to the grocery store, mid-sentence, to hear your toddler ask, "I want to get out!" You'd think you're going on a year-long journey to the other side of the world when you're just trying to make it to Target for two things.

And then—there's the great "shoes" debacle. You're finally, FINALLY, in the car, and they're wearing mismatched socks. The socks that were once, when they were placed on their feet five minutes ago, the epitome of cute. Now, they're just an obstacle because "one of the socks is too tight!" or "the socks are on the wrong feet!" This turns into a full-scale meltdown that somehow mysteriously makes you late for every single appointment.

When you finally get to your destination, you can't help but laugh (or cry) as you realise that every time someone told you to cherish the moments, they never warned you about the getting their part. The struggle to get into the car, the ten-minute battle over snacks, the crying fit when the wrong socks were worn—this is the reality that no one told you about when you were looking at your child's newborn face and hearing "it goes by so quickly."

They were right. It does go by quickly—but the moments when you're trying to get out the door and realizing you'll never be on time for anything again? Those are the moments that seem to stretch on forever. You'll get there eventually, but first, you'll need to load up the car, make sure everyone's comfortable, and prepare for that one last-minute negotiation about whether they need

to wear a coat—because heaven forbid, they ever agree on what's essential for the journey.

But here's the thing: while it may feel like getting out of the door takes forever, when you look back, you'll miss those tiny delays. The tantrums over shoes, the refusal to get in the car, the endless snack negotiations. Because, somehow, during the chaos, you realise—these moments really do fly by. And when they're older, and the rush to get out the door isn't a battle anymore, you'll strangely long for those days when life was filled with such little, silly delays.

Until, of course, you try to leave for the doctor appointment on a Saturday. Then, once again, it takes forever.

Chapter 17:

Laundry Never Ends

Ah, laundry. The constant companion of parenthood. Before kids, you used to think doing laundry was a simple chore. You'd toss a load in, maybe fold a few shirts, and call it a day. But then you became a parent. And suddenly, laundry isn't just a task—it's an infinite, unyielding mountain that refuses to be conquered.

You'll start with the basics. The constant, never-ending parade of baby clothes, burp cloths, and bibs. You swear to yourself that you just washed those tiny socks—how do they even get dirty so fast? But there they are again, tucked under the couch cushions or, for some reason, mysteriously stuck inside a toy car. You wash, you dry, you fold—and then it happens. Another load. It's like an insidious cycle. You can't escape it. You may be able to throw a load in the wash, but the minute you finish folding it, there's more. The laundry pile regenerates like it has a mind of its own.

And then, the clothes—they grow. You blink, and your baby's onesies are too small, and suddenly, you're dealing with bigger clothes. Shirts, pants, jackets—now they're staining everything. You wonder how so much dirt can get on one little

body. It's like they've discovered the art of getting as messy as humanly possible. One minute, it's food on their face. The next, it's mud from playing outside. The next, they've figured out how to eat spaghetti while sitting on the couch, and now there's sauce everywhere. You clean it up, wash the clothes, and boom—back to square one.

And don't even get me started on underwear. There's always a forgotten pair that makes its way into your laundry basket after weeks of being MIA. The endless cycle of socks that never match. You'll start with a perfect set, only for one sock to go missing—forever. That sock has disappeared into another dimension, and the other sock is just left there, waiting. Maybe one day, it'll show up?

And the laundry never stops—EVER. You start the day feeling like you've finally caught up on laundry, but by the time you finish that cup of coffee, there's a new accident. Someone spilled juice on their shirt. Someone forgot to wear a bib. Someone had a "craft session" with markers. The list goes on and on. At this point, it's not even about clean clothes anymore. It's about survival. You're just hoping to have enough socks that almost match and enough underwear for everyone to get through the day without a meltdown.

And when they get older, oh, it doesn't stop. Now, you're dealing with muddy soccer uniforms,

spilled paint on their shirts, and let's not forget the stinky shoes they refuse to take off. The laundry pile becomes a little bit more... fragrant. You'll find yourself doing laundry at 2 a.m. because the soccer game is in 12 hours, and someone forgot to tell you that their jersey wasn't clean. You'll start to fantasise about a world where clothes don't get dirty, or better yet—where kids wear one outfit every single day.

And just when you think you've made a dent in the pile, you realise you've missed a sock in the dryer, and the cycle begins again. You wonder if your washing machine is secretly working against you, multiplying socks like it's trying to sabotage you. And those lovely people who told you that laundry would somehow get easier as they get older? They were lying. As your child grows, they acquire more clothing. School uniforms, sports gear, jackets, hoodies, costumes from the latest obsession—all add to the never-ending pile of laundry you must tackle. It's like an eternal game of laundry Tetris—you'll never win. But you'll keep playing anyway.

The best part? You'll find yourself celebrating when you've finally folded that last sock and emptied the basket—only to realise it's full again because your kid just dropped an entire cup of spaghetti on their lap. So, you put in another load,

roll up your sleeves, and smile because you're a laundry warrior.

Sure, the laundry might never end, but there's a special satisfaction in knowing that one tiny piece of clothing at a time, you're keeping everything together. Even if it's just for a moment before the next spill, stain, or surprise.

Chapter 18:

They Don't Care About Your Embarrassment

Before becoming a parent, you had an idea of how your child would behave in public—polite, well-mannered, and not screaming at the top of their lungs while you frantically try to find the exit. Fast forward to parenthood, and you quickly learn that your child has no concept of social norms or personal boundaries—and worst of all, they have zero regard for your embarrassment.

Take, for example, the moment you're in the middle of a packed grocery store, and your toddler decides to have a meltdown because they're not getting the candy bar you might have just promised them as a bribe. They don't understand why you're suddenly "shushing" them in the middle of the aisle. Their decibel level is higher than the PA system, and people are starting to stare. You give them your best "this is fine" smile, but deep down, you're planning an escape route, wondering how many people are now judging you for your child's public display of utter chaos.

But nope, they don't care. They're just living their best life, throwing themselves on the floor like they've been wronged in the worst way possible.

And you? You're the one awkwardly trying to calm them down, all the while thinking, "Please, God, let this be over." The woman in the dairy aisle is judging you, and there's no escaping it.

Then, just when you think you've pulled it together, your child decides to loudly declare their latest thoughts on your parenting choices. Maybe it's, "Why is Papa angry?" Or, better yet, "Dada, why do you have so much hair in your nose?" Suddenly, you're that parent—the one whose child has no filter. The one who's wondering if they'll ever live down the moment when they stood in line at the store, smiling awkwardly as their child asked, "Why do you wear glasses?" loudly enough for the entire aisle to hear. Oh, the horror.

And it doesn't stop there. You're in the waiting room at the doctor's office, and your child asks, "Why does that man have a funny face?" as loudly as possible, while you pretend you didn't just hear it. You can practically hear the collective intake of breath from everyone around you, wondering if you're going to try to "shush" your child, or just die inside and move to a remote island. Either way, your child doesn't know what's going on. They're just processing the world as they see it, and if that involves commenting on someone's face in front of everyone—well, so be it.

And as for the inappropriate questions? Oh, they'll ask those, too. Like, "Why does that lady have big boobies?" or "Why does that man smell funny?" And don't even try to reason with them. They'll just keep asking it louder because that's how the world works when you're under five. They don't care who's around, who might be offended, or if you're standing in line at the bank with a stranger who might be the person they're talking about. It's just their world, and we're all just living in it.

But here's the thing: as much as it feels like everyone is watching and judging, you'll eventually realise that most people are too busy with their own lives to care about your minor parenting blunders. Sure, your kid might just loudly point out the fact that the cashier has a huge pimple, but chances are, the cashier has heard worse and is probably already planning to leave the job at the end of the shift. Plus, they've probably got their own kid at home doing the same thing.

At the end of the day, as embarrassing as those moments are, they pass. Your kid will grow up, and eventually, they'll learn the social nuances of when to keep quiet. But in the meantime? Embrace the chaos. Your child might not care about your embarrassment, but at least you will have a lifetime of hilarious stories to tell when they're

older. So, when your toddlers in the middle of loudly questioning why the person in front of you has “funny-looking shoes,” just remember—you’ll laugh about it later. Maybe even while you’re folding laundry at 2 a.m.

Chapter 19:

You'll Miss the Mess When They're Older

When you're in the thick of it—knee-deep in spilled cereal, strewn toys, and half-eaten crackers littering every surface—you can't imagine ever missing the chaos. You find yourself tidying up a hundred times a day, wondering if the mess is multiplying faster than you can clean it. Every surface seems to attract some kind of stuff. The house is like a magnet for crumbs, socks, and random bits of paper that your child will one day look at and say, "I made this for you!" But right now? It feels like you're living in a tiny tornado of toys, snacks, and laundry. You get frustrated, you sigh, and you wonder if it's even worth picking up after them at all.

But here's the thing: as time goes on, you'll notice something subtle—and kind of heartbreaking. One day, you'll look around and realise that the mess is starting to vanish. The toys aren't everywhere anymore. The floor isn't littered with the remnants of a hundred snack times. You'll have a perfectly clean-living room for maybe the first time ever, and you'll be so proud of your tidy home. But then, almost instinctively, you'll start to feel... lonely. Quiet. Empty. It's the weirdest feeling. You find yourself missing the clutter—the

action. The noise. Because, as much as it drove you nuts at the time, it was also life.

Your child is growing up. They're becoming more independent, learning how to keep their own room tidy (or at least not create chaos everywhere). They start to spend more time on their own hobbies, like reading or playing with friends. They're outgrowing their favourite toys and transitioning into things that are, well... less messy. The floor is clear. The fridge is no longer filled with leftover half-eaten snacks. The clutter of little shoes, books, and markers fades away. And as much as you swore, you'd never miss it, you find yourself standing in a clean house—and missing the mess.

You miss the days when they'd "help" you with the laundry (read: throw everything in a pile and then dive into it, creating a mess). You miss the sticky fingerprints on the walls, the crayon drawings that looked like a modern art exhibit, and the way their toys would be scattered across the floor in a beautiful, chaotic masterpiece of imagination.

Sure, it was a pain to step on a LEGO in the middle of the night or find that half-eaten banana in the couch cushions, but when the house is suddenly neat and quiet, you realise just how much life was in all that mess. There was a certain comfort in knowing that their stuff, their energy, and their

tiny human-ness was all over the place. It was a reminder that your home was filled with life, noise, and moments that couldn't be recreated.

You'll miss the chaos. The full toy bins. The trail of tiny shoes leading to the bedroom. The snacks that ended up in places they shouldn't be. And the mountain of laundry you couldn't keep up with, because each little stain or tear was a badge of honour. Those things signified a child—a tiny, adorable human who was growing, exploring, and figuring out the world around them in their own messy way.

Before you know it, they'll be packing their bags for a sleepover, asking for a "quiet weekend," or refusing to spend time with you because they've suddenly "outgrown" your silly, messy family traditions. You'll wonder where the time went, and you'll wish for the days when the mess was a sure sign that your home was full of love, laughter, and adventure.

And just like that, you'll look at the pristine kitchen counter and wish you could just find one lesser sock under the table. One more snack wrapper on the floor. One more toy car lodged between the couch cushions. Because, in the end, you realise that the mess wasn't just clutter—it was a memory. And one day, when they're older, you'll miss it. You'll miss the piles of laundry that

seemed impossible to manage, because it meant they were still there. Still messy. Still making memories.

So, here's the secret no one tells you: as you're grumbling about the mess now, savour it a little. One day, you'll look back and wish you had it all over again. Because, honestly, those messy, chaotic days? They were some of the bests of your life.

Chapter 20:

You'd Do It All Over Again?

When you're deep in the trenches of parenthood, there are days when you swear you can't go on. The sleepless nights, the tantrums, the endless laundry, and the constant mess—it can all feel like too much. You wonder, in those quiet moments of exhaustion, whether it would really be worth it if you had to do it all over again. Maybe just one more sleepless night. Maybe one more dirty diaper. Maybe you'll never, ever get a moment to yourself again.

But here's the thing: when you look at your child, all that frustration fades away. In the middle of all the chaos, there's a moment—a beautiful, life-changing moment—when you realise that yes, you would do it all over again. Maybe not another sibling (let's be honest, one is enough for now), but for Skye, you'd go through it all again, every single second.

You'd go through the sleepless nights again, the ones where you'd rock him back to sleep while half-dazed, just to hear him softly breathe and know that he's okay. You'd do it again for that tiny hand that gripped your finger for the first time, for the moments when you both just sat there, in

the middle of the mess, and realised that this was it—the greatest, hardest, most rewarding job in the world.

Yes, the chaos is relentless, and yes, the exhaustion can feel like a never-ending marathon. But when you look at Skye—at the little person you've raised, the one you've watched grow and learn and laugh—you know that every minute was worth it. Every messy room, every crayon mark on the wall, every hour spent trying to calm him down during his tantrums, has brought you to this moment where you wouldn't change a thing.

Sure, you might occasionally fantasise about a full night of sleep or a few uninterrupted hours, but when you see Skye's smile, hear his laugh, or watch him navigate the world with his ever-growing curiosity and joy, you realise that it's all worth it. Because this kid—the one you thought you couldn't possibly love more but somehow do with every passing day—has turned your world upside down in the best way possible.

So, would you do it all over again? In a heartbeat. Maybe not with another sibling (let's be real), but for him? Anytime. Because parenthood, despite its mess and its chaos, is a once-in-a-lifetime experience. And the moments that make you want to pull your hair out will be the very same ones you cherish forever.

And if it means doing it all over again for Skye?
Without question. For anyone else...hell no!

BONUS Chapter

The Toll Children Take on a Marriage

Children are often seen as a natural part of life for married couples. The idea of starting a family is painted as an idealised and joyful experience, one that brings completeness and fulfilment. However, the reality is more complex. While children undoubtedly bring immense joy and fulfilment, they can also place significant strain on a marriage. The stress of raising children can create rifts that reveal, or even exacerbate, underlying tensions within a relationship. This chapter delves into the toll that children can take on a marriage, with a focus on the critical reminder that children should never be used as a solution to fix a marriage in distress.

There's a common misconception that having a child can bring a couple closer, solve existing relationship problems, or act as a form of reconciliation. This belief often stems from the notion that a child will create a new shared purpose, revitalise intimacy, and bring new joy into the relationship. However, the reality is that children introduce an entirely new set of challenges that can stretch a marriage to its breaking point.

When a couple's relationship is already strained, introducing a child into the mix can shift the focus from nurturing the marital bond to managing the logistics of raising a child. Without proper attention to the marriage itself, this shift can lead to further disconnection.

Parenting itself is exhausting, requiring constant attention, energy, and adaptability. The arrival of a baby, in particular, changes nearly every aspect of daily life. Sleep deprivation, financial concerns, and the overwhelming responsibility of caring for another human being can create emotional strain. With the division of responsibilities and the need for cooperation, couples may find themselves arguing more frequently about parenting styles, discipline, and priorities. When this occurs, the marital bond can feel strained and fragmented.

A lack of time and energy for each other can lead to feelings of loneliness and frustration, especially if one partner feels the other is not pulling their weight. This lack of connection can leave both partners feeling unsupported and increasingly isolated.

Before children, couples often have more freedom to nurture their emotional and physical intimacy. Date nights, spontaneous trips, and private moments of connection are easier to come by. However, once children arrive, those moments of

intimacy become less frequent and more difficult to maintain. As the focus shifts toward the child's needs, couples may find it harder to prioritise their relationship.

The loss of physical intimacy is often one of the first signs of a marital strain. With the exhaustion and the busy schedules that children bring, couples may go for long periods without connecting intimately. This lack of intimacy can breed resentment and dissatisfaction, leading one or both partners to feel neglected or unappreciated.

Parenting duties often reinforce traditional gender roles, where one partner takes on the bulk of childcare and household responsibilities. Even in modern, more equal partnerships, the pressure of balancing work, parenting, and personal time can lead to resentment. The unequal distribution of labour—whether emotional, mental, or physical—can create tension within a marriage.

When one partner feels overburdened, it can lead to feelings of frustration and anger, which may manifest as arguments or emotional distance. Moreover, the expectation that one partner should “take the lead” on parenting can cause a sense of inequity that undermines the foundation of the relationship.

Children challenge a couple's communication skills in new ways. Parenting is a shared responsibility, but each partner may bring different ideas about how to handle their child's needs, discipline, and upbringing. Differing parenting styles can create conflict, especially if one partner feels that the other is too lenient, too strict, or too distant.

When communication is not handled with care and respect, disagreements can escalate, leading to misunderstandings or even long-lasting resentment. Poor communication can cause couples to feel like they're "parenting alone," despite being in the same household. Without effective communication, partners may feel that they are no longer in sync, causing additional strain on the marriage.

Children can place a significant financial burden on a marriage. The cost of raising a child, from diapers to education, can lead to stress and strain on a couple's finances. This, in turn, can impact the overall dynamics of the marriage.

When financial pressure builds, couples may find themselves fighting about money more often, which can quickly deteriorate the emotional connection. One partner may feel guilty or anxious about not contributing enough, while the other may feel overwhelmed by the weight of

providing for the family. Financial stress is often one of the most common causes of marital conflict, and it becomes even more pronounced when children's needs are factored in.

Parenting is hard work, and when both partners feel like they are constantly “on” with no time for rest or self-care, burnout can set in. The stress of managing children, work, and personal commitments without adequate support can result in exhaustion and emotional depletion.

When parents experience burnout, they are less able to provide the emotional and physical care their marriage needs. They may be short-tempered, distracted, or uninterested in nurturing their relationship. This emotional distance can create further disconnection, leading to feelings of resentment, guilt, and frustration.

Despite the many challenges children bring to a marriage, it's important to remember that the relationship between partners remains the foundation of the family. While children require time and attention, it is crucial to carve out moments to nurture the marital bond. Whether it's through small gestures of affection, regular communication, or scheduling time to be together without the children, maintaining the relationship is essential.

Couples who prioritise their relationship and invest time in each other are more likely to weather the storms of parenthood without losing their connection. Recognizing that the marriage is the cornerstone of family life can provide couples with the strength and resilience needed to navigate the challenges of raising children.

Children can bring immense joy, but they also bring a level of stress and responsibility that can challenge a marriage. It's important to remember that children are not a fix for a troubled relationship. No matter how much love or joy a child can bring, if the relationship between the parents is weak or fractured, it will be difficult to maintain a healthy family dynamic. Marriage requires effort, attention, and care, and this doesn't change when children come into the picture.

Couples must understand that the health of the marriage is foundational to the family's well-being. To thrive as parents and partners, couples need to make space for their relationship, communicate openly, share responsibilities, and support each other. Parenting is hard, but it doesn't have to break a marriage—if the couple is committed to navigating the journey together.

In the end...know you are not alone in this circus
they call parenting. I see you, I feel you and I
understand!

It really takes a village.... thanks to my village!

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In **Finding Your Spotlight**, the author delves into the concept of purpose, sharing personal anecdotes and life lessons that have shaped his journey. From pivotal moments like military training and international travel to navigating various careers, the narrative highlights the importance of making proactive decisions, embracing one's unique path, and striving for continuous self-improvement. Through insightful quotes and practical tips, the author emphasizes the need to create opportunities rather than merely seeking them and encourages readers to find and fulfil their own purpose with intention and preparation thus stepping into their own SPOTLIGHT.

Directions to Gay Town: Thea Rainbow Road Map is a heartfelt and humorous exploration of LGBTQ+ life, discussing the absurdity of coming out, online dating, how to navigate relationships, to finding "The One." Each chapter mixes witty anecdotes with deep insights, celebrating the joys and challenges of living authentically in a vibrant, evolving world.